

Governance, Law, and Sectarian Division in Northern Ireland: A Constitutional Analysis

The constitutional and political architecture of Northern Ireland represents one of the most intricate frameworks of conflict resolution and post-conflict governance in the modern world. Engineered primarily through the Belfast (Good Friday) Agreement of 1998 and subsequently codified in the Northern Ireland Act 1998, the system relies on consociationalism—a form of mandatory power-sharing designed to ensure that neither the unionist nor the nationalist community can exercise majoritarian dominance. However, the exact legal mechanisms designed to foster stability frequently become the battlegrounds for deep-seated sectarian and political disputes.

Triggered by the recent and highly volatile legal dispute surrounding the Orange Order parade on the Garvaghy Road in Portadown in September 2026, this analysis undertakes an exhaustive examination of the structures of the Northern Irish government. It maps the legal mechanics of the power-sharing agreement, the distribution of power between devolved and sovereign actors, and the specialized public bodies that regulate sectarian division, such as the Parades Commission. By charting the intersection of statutory obligations, executive vetoes, and landmark judicial interventions—from the historic *Robinson* case to recent post-Brexit litigation over the Windsor Framework—this report delineates how power is distributed, contested, and adjudicated in a deeply divided society.

The Regulation of Contested Space: The Parades Commission

In Northern Ireland, the physical manifestation of sectarian division frequently occurs through public processions. The tradition of parading, predominantly but not exclusively maintained by loyalist and unionist fraternities such as the Orange Order, has historically served as a flashpoint for communal violence. To depoliticize the regulation of these marches, the Parades Commission was established as a quasi-judicial, non-departmental public body under the Public Processions (Northern Ireland) Act 1998.

Statutory Remit and Structural Composition

The Parades Commission effectively removed the power to ban or restrict marches from the Secretary of State for Northern Ireland and the police force, placing it in the hands of an independent body comprising seven members appointed by the Secretary of State. Its primary function is to adjudicate on contentious parades, placing restrictions on routes, timing, music, and participant numbers where necessary to preserve public order and community relations. Under Section 8(1) of the Public Processions (Northern Ireland) Act 1998, the Commission is granted the power to impose conditions on proposed public processions. When making a determination, Section 8(6) dictates that the Commission must have regard to five statutory criteria. The table below outlines these criteria and their application.

Statutory Criterion (Section 8(6))	Commission Application and Interpretation
Public Disorder or Damage to Property	The immediate security implications of the parade, assessed via formal advice and intelligence from the Police Service of Northern Ireland (PSNI).
Disruption to the Life of the Community	The degree to which the parade restricts freedom of movement, access to businesses, hospitals, and places of worship, ensuring disruption is not disproportionate.
Impact on Relationships within the Community	Evaluates the demographic balance of the route, the presence of sensitive sites (e.g., Catholic churches in Protestant areas or vice versa), and the long-term history of inter-community strife.
Compliance with the Code of Conduct	Whether the parade organizers and counter-protesters have previously adhered to statutory guidelines regarding behavior, dialogue, and non-provocative engagement.
Desirability of Customary Routes	The traditional nature of the parade, balancing the right to free assembly against the right of local residents to live free from intimidation.

The 2026 Garvaghy Road Dispute: A Case Study in Judicial Review

The fragility of this regulatory framework was exposed in late September 2026, when the Parades Commission issued a determination allowing the Portadown District Loyal Orange Lodge to march along the predominantly nationalist Garvaghy Road in Portadown for the first time in 28 years. The annual Drumcree march had been banned from this specific route since 1998 following widespread sectarian violence, which tragically included the murder of three Catholic children in a petrol bomb attack in Ballymoney.

The Commission's 2026 decision was heavily restricted. The parade was limited to 35 participants, required to proceed in silence without bands, and scheduled for 8:00 am to minimize disruption to a local Catholic Mass. The Commission noted that the Orange Order had complied with over 1,300 previous rulings barring their route over two decades, and the PSNI indicated no specific intelligence suggesting the 2026 parade would result in property damage. However, the decision triggered immediate legal and civil contestation, leading to an extraordinary sequence of weekend court sittings.

The Garvaghy Road Residents Coalition sought an emergency judicial review. In the High Court, Justice Patricia Smyth issued a temporary injunction suspending the parade, citing the fundamental potential for the dispute to escalate across Northern Ireland. She urged the parties to step back from the abyss, noting that the level of mistrust between the residents and the Orange Lodge could not be overstated.

Yet, in a late-night sitting of the Court of Appeal, Lady Chief Justice Siobhan Keegan overturned the injunction, ruling that the lower court had erred in law. A final, early-hours application at the High Court before Justice Michael Humphreys was similarly dismissed. Humphreys articulated the core administrative law principle governing the Parades Commission: as a statutory public body, its decisions command deference. The court's jurisdiction to impugn such a decision is strictly limited to cases of *Wednesbury* unreasonableness—instances where no reasonable

public body could have arrived at the outcome. Because the Commission had taken evidence, weighed the statutory criteria under Section 8, and arrived at a reasoned decision, the threshold for judicial interference was not met.

The political fallout was immediate and sharply divided along sectarian lines. First Minister Michelle O'Neill (Sinn Féin) condemned the decision as disgraceful, stating it brought into question how the entire peace process works, while Sinn Féin leader Mary Lou McDonald called it utterly reckless. The SDLP's Claire Hanna termed it provocative, and the Taoiseach of the Republic of Ireland, Micheál Martin, described it as incomprehensible and wrong. Conversely, Democratic Unionist Party (DUP) leader Gavin Robinson celebrated the legal victory, criticizing O'Neill for standing with protesters and insisting that Orangemen walking silently should not be a major issue in a shared society. UK Prime Minister Andy Burnham and Northern Ireland Secretary Chris Bryant appealed for cool heads, insisting that the rule of law and court decisions must be respected.

Despite the legal victory for the Orange Order, the reality of policing a divided society superseded the court order. On the morning of the march, PSNI Chief Constable Jon Boucher intervened and prevented the parade from proceeding down the Garvaghy Road due to a blockade by hundreds of nationalist protesters, emphasizing that the primary objective was ensuring no one was harmed. This sequence of events perfectly encapsulates a core governance insight in Northern Ireland: statutory legal frameworks and judicial rulings are frequently subordinated to the physical realities of community opposition and public order policing.

The Architecture of Consociational Government: The Northern Ireland Assembly and Executive

The macro-level governance of Northern Ireland operates under the Northern Ireland Act 1998, which translated the Good Friday Agreement into domestic UK law. The Act establishes a mandatory coalition government structure heavily reliant on mutual vetoes, demographic proportionality, and cross-community consent.

The Diarchy of the First Minister and Deputy First Minister

Unlike standard parliamentary democracies where the executive is formed by a majority party or a voluntary coalition, the Northern Ireland Executive is led by the First Minister and the deputy First Minister. Despite the differing titles, the offices represent a joint diarchy. They possess identical legal powers, act jointly, and if one resigns, the other immediately falls from office. This structural interdependence guarantees that the largest unionist party and the largest nationalist party must govern cooperatively, or not at all.

Below the First Minister and deputy First Minister, ministerial portfolios are allocated using the d'Hondt method. The d'Hondt formula is a mathematical mechanism based on the number of seats a party holds in the Northern Ireland Assembly. This prevents the systematic exclusion of minority parties from the Executive. However, it also eliminates the concept of an official opposition, meaning the government is frequently composed of ideological adversaries who fundamentally disagree on the constitutional status of the state.

The Role of the Secretary of State for Northern Ireland

While power is devolved to Stormont, the UK Government retains ultimate sovereignty, exercised through the Secretary of State for Northern Ireland. The Secretary of State possesses wide-ranging powers under the Northern Ireland Act 1998, particularly regarding excepted and reserved matters such as national security, international relations, and taxation.

Crucially, under Section 1(1) and Schedule 1 of the Act (often referred to as the border poll provision), the Secretary of State is legally obligated to call a referendum on Irish reunification if it appears likely that a majority of those voting would express a wish for Northern Ireland to cease being part of the United Kingdom. Furthermore, under Section 26 of the Act, the Secretary of State can issue directions or revoke subordinate legislation if a Northern Ireland Minister's actions are deemed incompatible with the UK's international obligations (such as treaties with the EU) or national security.

Mechanics of Veto: Cross-Community Consent and the Petition of Concern

To safeguard minority rights, the Assembly operates on the principle of cross-community consent. Members of the Legislative Assembly must designate themselves as Unionist, Nationalist, or Other. Contentious legislation can be subjected to a Petition of Concern. If 30 Members of the Legislative Assembly sign a Petition of Concern, the matter in question cannot pass by a simple majority; it requires either parallel consent (a majority of all voting members, including a majority of both designated unionists and nationalists) or a weighted majority (60 percent overall, including 40 percent of both unionists and nationalists).

Historically, the Petition of Concern was weaponized by the largest parties to unilaterally veto social legislation, creating widespread democratic dysfunction and institutional gridlock.

Reforms: The New Decade, New Approach (NDNA)

Following a three-year collapse of the Executive (2017–2020) precipitated by a botched green energy scheme, the UK and Irish governments brokered the *New Decade, New Approach* (NDNA) agreement in January 2020. The NDNA introduced vital structural reforms to address the systemic flaws in the 1998 architecture.

The Petition of Concern mechanism was altered to require members from two or more political parties to trigger it, eliminating the ability of a single large party to wield an absolute veto independently. A mandatory 14-day consideration period was also introduced to cool political tensions. Furthermore, the rules surrounding executive formation were amended. Previously, if the First Minister and deputy First Minister offices became vacant, an election had to be called within six weeks. The Northern Ireland (Ministers, Elections and Petitions of Concern) Act 2022, born from the NDNA, extended this to a maximum of 24 weeks (four successive six-week periods), allowing caretaker ministers to remain in post to provide administrative continuity during political crises. The NDNA also included provisions for linguistic diversity, establishing commissioners for the Irish language and Ulster Scots.

Feature of Governance	Original 1998 Mechanism	Post-2020 NDNA Reform
Petition of Concern	30 signatures required; often triggered by a single large party.	30 signatures from at least two parties; 14-day cooling-off period.
Executive Formation	6-week window before mandatory dissolution.	Extended to 24 weeks (four 6-week blocks) to allow

Feature of Governance	Original 1998 Mechanism	Post-2020 NDNA Reform
		negotiation.
Ministerial Continuity	Ministers fell immediately upon collapse.	Caretaker ministers remain in post during the 24-week window.

Landmark Constitutional Litigation and Sectarian Division

Because Northern Ireland's governance relies on rigid, statutory consociational rules rather than flexible political conventions, political deadlocks frequently end up in the courts. The judiciary is routinely forced to interpret the boundaries of ministerial power, cross-cutting consent, statutory obligations, and human rights in a divided society.

The Constitutional Statute Doctrine: *Robinson v Secretary of State*

The foundational case defining the legal nature of the Northern Ireland Act 1998 is *Robinson v Secretary of State for Northern Ireland (2002)*. In 2001, the six-week statutory time limit for the Assembly to elect a First and Deputy First Minister expired without successful appointments. Several days later, a political breakthrough allowed the appointments to proceed. Peter Robinson (DUP) challenged the appointments, arguing a literal interpretation of the statute: once the six weeks elapsed, the Secretary of State was legally obligated to dissolve the Assembly and call fresh elections, rendering any late appointments ultra vires.

The House of Lords dismissed the challenge in a landmark ruling. Lord Bingham declared that while the Northern Ireland Act 1998 was an Act of the UK Parliament, it was in effect a constitution for Northern Ireland. Therefore, it should not be read with strict, mechanistic literalism, but must be interpreted generously and purposively, bearing in mind the values which the constitutional provisions are intended to embody. Lord Hoffmann concurred, noting that the entire purpose of the Act was to create a favorable environment for cross-community government, and dissolving the assembly over a technical deadline contravened that primary objective.

This ruling established the doctrine that the 1998 Act is a constitutional statute. It dictates that within the Northern Irish context, the courts will prioritize political flexibility and the survival of cross-community stability over rigid time-limit formalism.

The Parades Commission and Human Rights: *Tweed's Application*

Just as *Robinson* defined the constitutional statute doctrine, *Tweed v Parades Commission for Northern Ireland (2006)* defined the administrative and human rights obligations of public bodies regulating sectarian space. David Tweed, representing an Orange Lodge, challenged the Commission's refusal to allow a parade in Dunloy, seeking judicial review on the grounds that the decision was a disproportionate interference with his rights to free assembly under the European Convention on Human Rights.

The critical legal issue centered on the discovery of documents. The Commission argued that releasing internal documents detailing community objections would breach assurances of confidentiality given to nationalist residents. The House of Lords ruled that in cases engaging human rights proportionality, the courts must have access to the underlying evidence to assess

whether the public body struck a fair balance. This ruling compelled the Commission to adopt highly formalized, transparent evidence-gathering procedures, establishing that secret intelligence cannot be the sole basis for restricting human rights without judicial scrutiny.

The Limits of Bureaucracy: *The Buick Case*

If *Robinson* demonstrated judicial flexibility to save the institutions, the *Buick* litigation (2018) demonstrated the strict limits of governance in the absence of elected politicians. During the 2017–2020 Executive collapse, Northern Ireland's civil servants took over the day-to-day running of departments. A senior civil servant in the Department for Infrastructure granted planning permission for a highly controversial waste incinerator at Mallusk.

A local resident, Buick, challenged the decision. The Court of Appeal ruled that under the Northern Ireland Act 1998 and the Departments (NI) Order 1999, departments are strictly under the direction of ministers. More critically, because the incinerator impacted multiple departments, it was a cross-cutting decision. Under Section 20 of the NI Act 1998 and the Ministerial Code (codified under Section 28A), cross-cutting, significant, or controversial decisions require collective agreement by the full Executive Committee. The court ruled that civil servants had no legal authority to make such decisions in a political vacuum, severely paralyzing civil service governance and forcing Westminster to pass emergency primary legislation to provide legal cover for basic administrative functions.

Weaponizing the Ministerial Code: *Rooney & DAERA Minister (2022)*

The tension between international obligations and the internal rules of the Executive reached a boiling point in the post-Brexit era, culminating in the *Rooney / DAERA Minister* judicial review. Following Brexit, the UK and EU agreed to the Northern Ireland Protocol to avoid a hard land border in Ireland. The Protocol kept Northern Ireland inside the EU's single market for goods, mandating customs and sanitary checks on goods arriving from Great Britain at Northern Irish ports. These checks were vehemently opposed by unionist politicians who viewed them as severing their constitutional link to the rest of the UK.

In February 2022, Edwin Poots (DUP), the Minister for Agriculture, Environment and Rural Affairs (DAERA), issued a formal instruction ordering his staff to immediately cease conducting the legally required border checks. Poots argued that under Section 28A of the Northern Ireland Act 1998 and the Ministerial Code, the implementation of the Protocol was significant, controversial, and cross-cutting. Therefore, he claimed he lacked the legal authority to continue the checks without the collective approval of the Executive Committee—an approval he knew the DUP would veto.

Edward Rooney and Belfast City Council immediately sought a judicial review. The High Court delivered a scathing rejection of the Minister's legal reasoning. The court ruled that the obligation to carry out the border checks was a hard statutory duty imposed on DAERA by Section 7A of the European Union (Withdrawal) Act 2018, which transposed the Withdrawal Agreement into domestic law.

Crucially, the court established that a minister cannot use the internal consociational mechanisms of the Northern Ireland Act 1998 (specifically Section 28A and the requirement for Executive approval) as a shield to absolve themselves from complying with binding, primary statutory obligations. The judge noted the remarkable departure in the Minister's evidence and implied that the invocation of Section 28A was a political maneuver designed to frustrate the law, rather than a genuine interpretation of ministerial limits. The instruction to halt checks was

quashed.

This case provides a profound insight into modern Northern Irish politics: consociational legal mechanisms, originally designed to prevent the oppression of minorities, are frequently weaponized by political actors as tactical vetoes to paralyze government action when they disagree with overriding UK or international law.

Colliding Rights and Section 28A: The SPUC Abortion Challenge

The complexities of cross-cutting rules and ministerial authority were similarly litigated in the *Society for the Protection of Unborn Children (SPUC) Pro-Life Ltd's Application*. Following the decriminalization of abortion in Northern Ireland by the UK Parliament, the Secretary of State issued directions requiring the Northern Ireland Department of Health to commission full abortion services.

SPUC challenged the implementation, arguing that such a significant and controversial matter required Executive Committee approval under Section 28A of the Northern Ireland Act 1998, and that the Minister of Health lacked unilateral authority to proceed. The courts ultimately recognized that the Secretary of State held statutory powers to compel action to ensure compliance with human rights obligations, bypassing the local cross-cutting veto mechanism when devolved ministers failed to act expeditiously. This further established that Westminster retains the ultimate legal supremacy to override local consociational blockades when international or fundamental human rights obligations are at stake.

Conflict Legacy in the Courts: The Martin Neeson Case

Sectarian and conflict-related divisions permeate even routine administrative law. In the *Martin Neeson* judgment, the courts examined the employability of individuals with conflict-related convictions. Neeson, who had an unspent conflict-related conviction predating the Good Friday Agreement, was denied civil service clearance. The litigation highlighted the specific guidance in Northern Ireland that conflict-related offenses predating April 1998 should not bar employment unless manifestly incompatible with the role. The case underscored how the legacy of the conflict requires bespoke legal frameworks to reintegrate former combatants into society, demonstrating that the shadow of the Troubles influences public sector employment law just as heavily as it does constitutional law.

Post-Brexit Realities: The Windsor Framework and the Stormont Brake

The Brexit settlement fundamentally disrupted the delicate constitutional equilibrium of Northern Ireland. The Northern Ireland Protocol effectively placed a trade border in the Irish Sea, which unionists argued violated the Act of Union 1800 and the principle of consent enshrined in the Good Friday Agreement.

To address these concerns, UK Prime Minister Rishi Sunak and the EU negotiated the Windsor Framework in 2023. The Framework reduced friction by introducing Green Lanes (minimal checks for goods staying in Northern Ireland) and Red Lanes (full customs checks for goods moving into the Republic of Ireland and the EU).

The Legal Mechanics of the Stormont Brake

The most constitutionally significant innovation of the Windsor Framework is the Stormont Brake. Designed to address the democratic deficit of EU laws applying to Northern Ireland without local input, the Brake allows a minimum of 30 Members of the Legislative Assembly from at least two parties to notify the UK Government that they object to the application of an amended or replacement EU act.

If the Brake is validly pulled, the EU law is suspended, and the UK Government can ultimately veto its application in Northern Ireland, triggering arbitration with the EU. However, the mechanism is heavily caveated. It can only be used in the most exceptional circumstances and as a last resort, and the politicians must demonstrate a significant impact on the everyday lives of communities.

The Dispute over Consent Mechanisms

The Windsor Framework also mandates that the Northern Ireland Assembly hold a periodic democratic consent vote on the continuation of the core trade alignments of the agreement. Crucially, this vote operates on a simple majority basis, completely bypassing the cross-community consent rules (Petition of Concern) that govern internal Assembly matters. This majoritarian approach has infuriated unionist politicians. Jim Allister, leader of the Traditional Unionist Voice (TUV), and senior figures in the DUP have brought extensive legal challenges against the Protocol and the Framework. In *Allister et al.'s Application*, they argued that the new trade arrangements illegally override the foundational guarantees of the 1998 Agreement and the equal footing of trade guaranteed by the Act of Union. The courts have consistently ruled that the EU Withdrawal Act, as primary legislation passed by the sovereign UK Parliament, legally supersedes the older statutes.

As geopolitical analysts note, affording a minority unionist bloc an absolute veto over an international trade treaty was politically impossible for both Westminster and Brussels. The use of simple majority voting for the Windsor Framework consent mechanism represents a pragmatic, realpolitik override of Northern Ireland's standard consociational rules.

The PSNI, Security, and the Financial Cost of Division

The failure of political and legal mechanisms to seamlessly resolve sectarian divides ultimately places a massive operational and financial burden on the Police Service of Northern Ireland. While general crime rates in Northern Ireland are lower than in England and Wales, the policing environment is vastly more complex due to the ongoing terrorist threat, the policing of contentious parades, and the investigation of historical Troubles murders.

The financial toll of this division is severe. The table below outlines the distinct financial pressures the PSNI faces outside of standard policing duties.

Financial Pressure Area	Cost / Impact
Parading and Bonfires	Approximately £4.5 million in 2023.
Historical Legacy Investigations	£94 million spent over the last decade reinvestigating murders from 1969-2004.
Legacy Civil Litigation	£18.5 million spent resourcing the team dealing with legacy litigation (2018-present).
Total Legacy Expenditure	£160 million over the last 10 years.

Financial Pressure Area	Cost / Impact
Omagh Bombing Inquiry	Estimated lifetime cost to the PSNI of £12 million to £15 million.

PSNI Chief Constable Jon Boutcher has consistently warned that the requirement to fund these unique, post-conflict pressures out of a standard policing budget severely degrades neighborhood policing and the capability to tackle modern organized crime. Benchmarking police funding by conventional UK standards does not account for the complexity of policing in a society emerging from conflict. As evidenced during the September 2026 Garvaghy Road incident, where significant resources were deployed to manage the standoff, the police frequently serve as the physical buffer for disputes that the Parades Commission and the courts fail to permanently defuse.

Synthesis: The Efficacy of the Consociational Model

Evaluating the structures of the Northern Irish government requires acknowledging a fundamental paradox. The legal mechanisms designed to guarantee peace are the very mechanisms that ensure perpetual political instability. The mandatory inclusion of all major political identities via the d'Hondt method successfully ended three decades of armed conflict by ensuring neither community could be structurally disenfranchised. Furthermore, shifting the regulation of explosive issues like parading to independent bodies such as the Parades Commission removes direct political interference and anchors decisions in standardized, human-rights-compliant criteria. The judicial branch has also proven highly effective as a constitutional circuit breaker. As demonstrated in *Robinson*, the courts have the latitude to act as neutral arbiters, prioritizing the survival of the power-sharing framework over rigid adherence to procedural deadlines. Conversely, the mutual vetoes inherent in the Petition of Concern and Section 28A of the Northern Ireland Act 1998 incentivize brinkmanship. Politicians routinely collapse the Executive to leverage concessions from Westminster, resulting in massive governance gaps. Furthermore, cases like *Rooney* demonstrate how politicians attempt to weaponize the Ministerial Code to evade primary legal obligations, forcing the judiciary to continually referee purely political disputes. By requiring elected representatives to designate as Unionist or Nationalist, the system structurally disadvantages non-aligned, center-ground parties and discourages the emergence of normal socio-economic politics, ensuring that every administrative decision carries the weight of a constitutional crisis.

Taxonomy for Deeper Research

For researchers seeking to deepen their understanding of Northern Ireland's constitutional mechanics, the following taxonomy of key terminology, statutes, and jurisprudence serves as a critical foundation for further investigation.

Critical Legislation and Treaties

Legislation / Treaty	Significance
Northern Ireland Act 1998	The foundational constitutional statute. Key sections include Section 1 (Border Polls), Section 20 (Executive Committee), Section 26

Legislation / Treaty	Significance
	(Secretary of State override), and Section 28A (Ministerial Code).
Public Processions (NI) Act 1998	The legislation governing the Parades Commission. Section 8 dictates the five criteria for evaluating contentious marches.
The Windsor Framework (2023)	The UK-EU agreement replacing the Northern Ireland Protocol, introducing the Green/Red lanes and the Stormont Brake.
New Decade, New Approach (2020)	The political agreement that reformed the Petition of Concern and extended the executive formation window to 24 weeks.

Landmark Jurisprudence

Case Name	Core Legal Principle Established
<i>Robinson v Secretary of State (2002)</i>	Established that the NI Act 1998 is a constitutional statute requiring purposive interpretation to preserve power-sharing.
<i>In re Buick (2018)</i>	Defined the limits of civil service power in the absence of ministers and clarified cross-cutting decisions under Section 20.
<i>Rooney v DAERA Minister (2022)</i>	Established that the Ministerial Code (Section 28A) cannot veto primary statutory obligations derived from international treaties.
<i>Tweed v Parades Commission (2006)</i>	A critical ruling regarding human rights proportionality and the forced disclosure of confidential documents by public bodies.

Key Conceptual Terminology

Term	Definition
Consociationalism	A political science concept describing power-sharing in divided societies, characterized by grand coalitions and mutual vetoes.
d'Hondt Mechanism	The mathematical formula used to allocate ministerial portfolios based on party strength.
Petition of Concern	The cross-community veto mechanism requiring parallel or weighted majorities to pass contentious legislation.
The Stormont Brake	The mechanism allowing 30 MLAs to object to new EU regulations applying to Northern Ireland under the Windsor Framework.
Wednesbury Unreasonableness	The high threshold in administrative law required to overturn a decision made by a specialized public body.

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